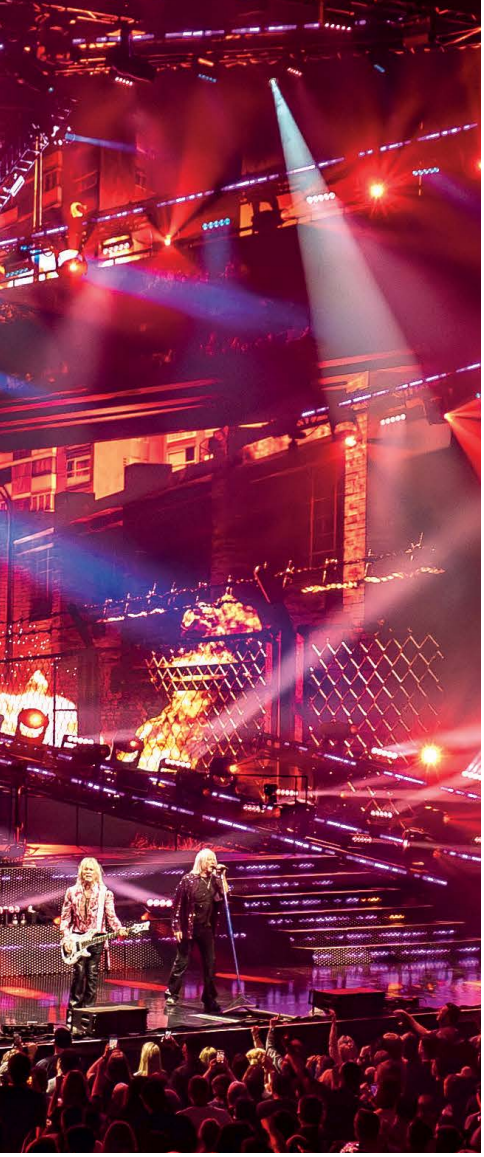


Despite being one of the best-selling bands of all time, Def Leppard have never won a Grammy or been the critics' favourites. Elliot says they don't seek that kind of validation, which for them comes "when the poster says 'sold out'".

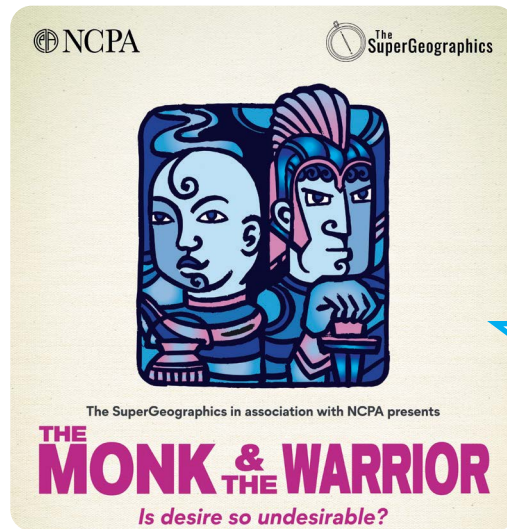
They're a band that doesn't take their listeners for granted, so fans can expect to hear almost all their biggest hits, like concert-closer 'Pour Some Sugar On Me'. "It never gets old," says Elliot. "If the crowd loves it, what's not to love?" He doesn't think much of artists who grudge singing their most famous songs. "If you can't handle the responsibility of a hit, then don't write one. Because you're going to [have to play it at] every gig. It's boring as hell in rehearsal, but never boring in front of a crowd." And this time, India gets to experience it live. ■

—Amit Gurbaxani

THEATRE ▼

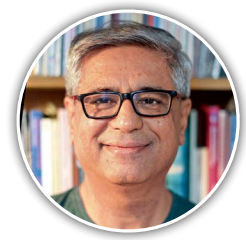
Love Without Borders

Mahesh Dattani's new play explores India's queer histories



While the stage has never lacked for grand romances, playwright Mahesh Dattani believes it is high time the spotlight shifts to a different kind of devotion. "We have already discovered through the classic tales of Sohni-Mahiwal, Romeo and Juliet, and Radha-Krishna that love transcends the barriers of class, caste and family," the Sahitya Akademi awardee notes. "Now, yet another barrier comes down," he says.

In association with the NCPA, Dattani's latest work, *The Monk & The Warrior*, is an ambitious collaboration with Brooklyn-based director Jonathan Taikina Taylor. The play starts with the historically accurate encounter between Alexander the Great and a Bodhisattva monk, which explodes into a love story that traverses culture, space and time, weaving together queer histories across centuries and civilisations.



The Monk & The Warrior leads audiences through a fantastical, episodic journey into India's queer histories, revisiting several folklores such as Chandravati and Malavati and Shams and Rumi, among others, to propose what some might say is quite radical: queerness is not a Western construct. It is a traditional part of Indian culture. Taylor, who first came to India seven years ago, says he was introduced to a number of queer artists, mythologists and activists by his friend, theatre actor and director Akhshay Gandhi. "It touched me how we could connect through queerness, despite our cultural and historical baggage. I wanted to make a play about that tension, how queerness could be an opposition to, or a salve for, colonisation," he says.

HISTORY RECAST
The play opens with an encounter between Alexander the Great and a Bodhisattva monk that unfolds into a love story; (below) playwright Mahesh Dattani

Ultimately, Dattani believes the play's purpose is to bring a simple story of love between two characters unlikely to fall in love, and the broader theme of relinquishing power and genocidal tendencies. The production boasts of cast members from across the globe, with music composed by Finnish composer Eero Hämeenniemi. Additionally, Tomás Carrasco Gubernatis, a composer and Chilean woodwind player, along with Prasoon Bhargava, an Indian musician and actor, will be performing live on stage. ■

—Deepali Dhingra

The play will be staged from ***Apr. 2-5*** *at the NCPA, Mumbai*